MESA AI-NATIVE TRACK - COHORT C4
PRE-READ: Supabase Account Setup
Complete this before Lecture 1 on 18 September 2026

WHAT IS SUPABASE AND WHY DO YOU NEED IT?

Every app you build this month needs somewhere to store data - user inputs, session history, results. Supabase is your database.

Think of it like a Google Sheet that your app can read from and write to automatically, in real time, without you manually updating anything.

Supabase is free for the scale of projects in this course. Setup takes about 10 minutes. You only need to do this once.

BEFORE YOU START

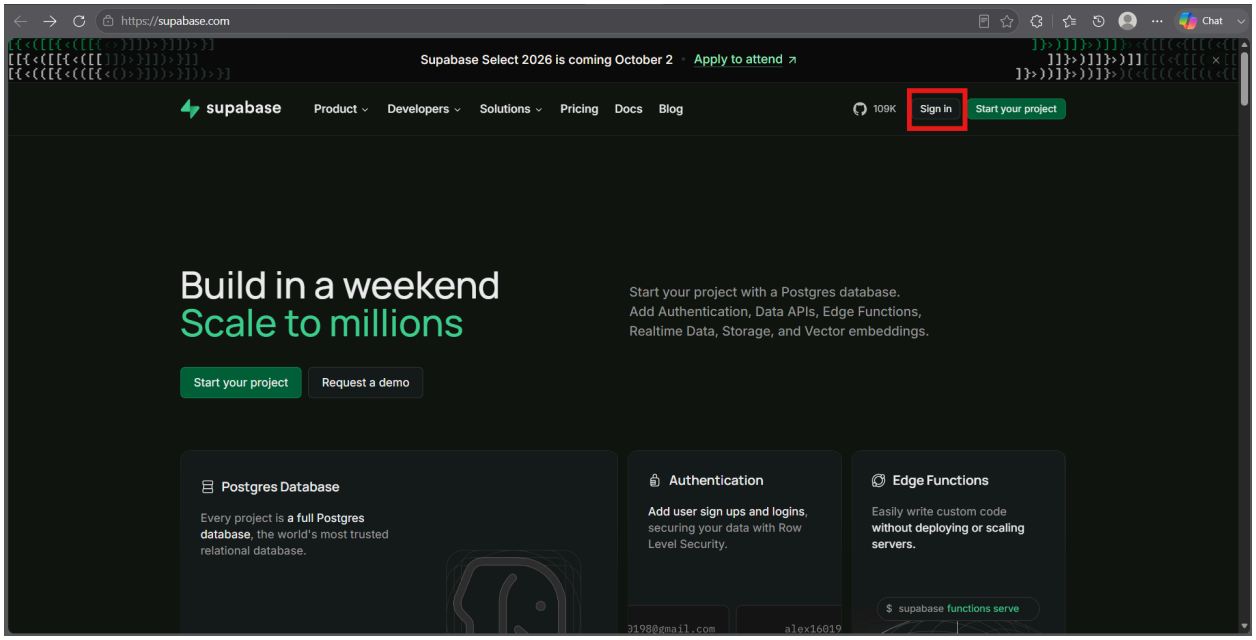
· Complete the GitHub pre-read first. You will use your GitHub account to sign into Supabase - no separate password needed.
· Do this on a laptop or desktop, not a phone.
· Have a notes app or password manager open. You will need to save three things during this setup.

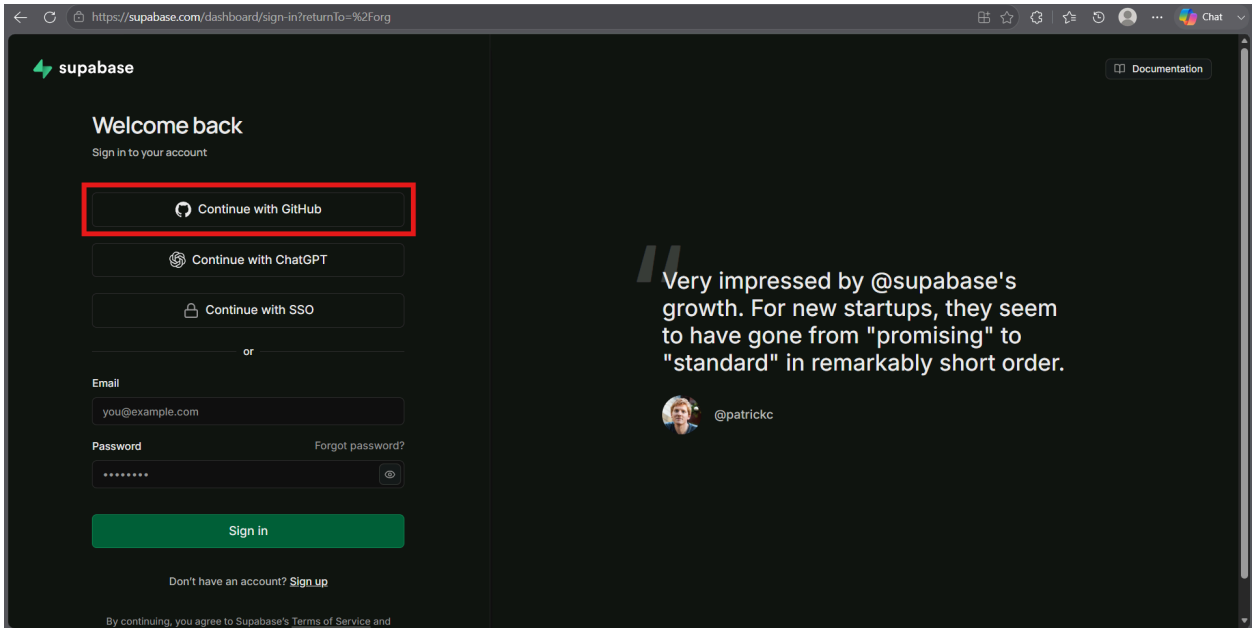
PART 1 — CREATE YOUR SUPABASE ACCOUNT

Go to supabase.com and click Start your project or Sign Up.

On the sign-up page, click Continue with GitHub. Since you already created a GitHub account in the previous pre-read, this is the fastest option - no new username or password needed.

GitHub will ask you to authorise Supabase to access your account. Click the green Authorize supabase button.





You will land on your Supabase dashboard.

PART 2 — CREATE YOUR FIRST PROJECT

Each app you build this month gets its own Supabase project. For now you are just setting up your first one - you will create more when the cases begin.

Click New project. You will see a form with three fields.

STEP 1 — Name your project

In the Name field, type:

mesa-ai-track

Keep it lowercase with hyphens - no spaces or special characters. This is just a label for your reference.

STEP 2 — Set your database password

This is the most important step in this guide.

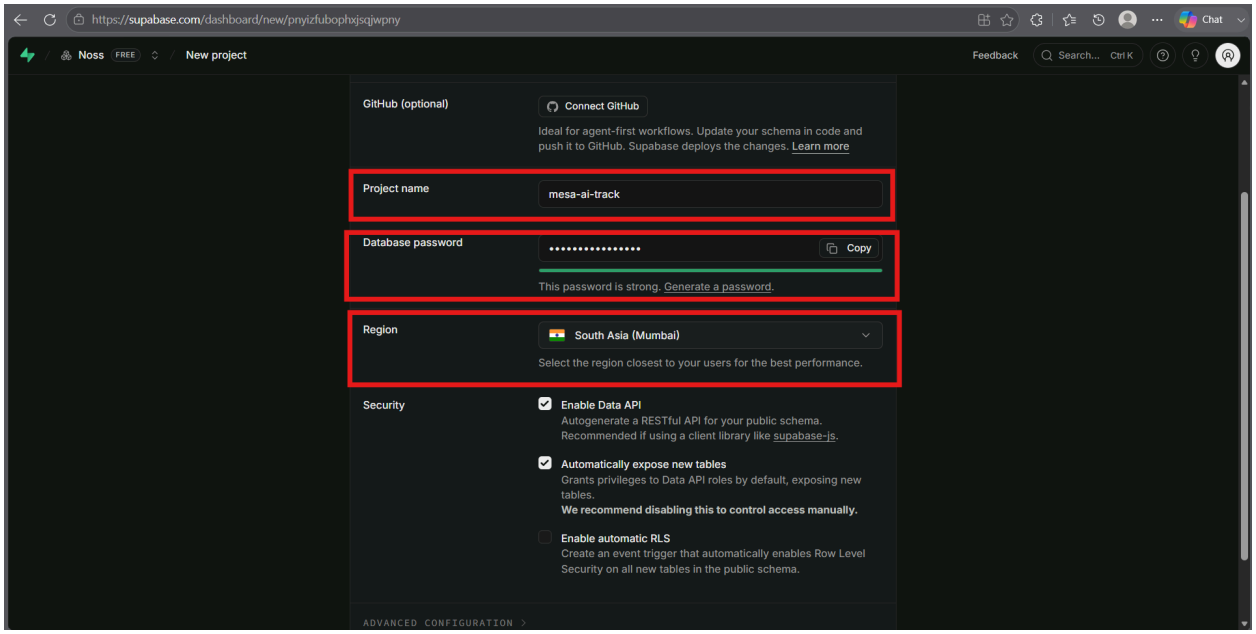
Supabase will generate a strong password for you automatically - you will see it pre-filled in the Database Password field. You can use this generated one or create your own.

Whatever the password is: copy it and save it somewhere safe right now.

This password cannot be recovered after this step. Supabase will not show it to you again. If you lose it, you will need to reset it, which disrupts any apps already connected to this database. ***Save it before you move on.***

STEP 3 — Choose your region

Click the Region dropdown.

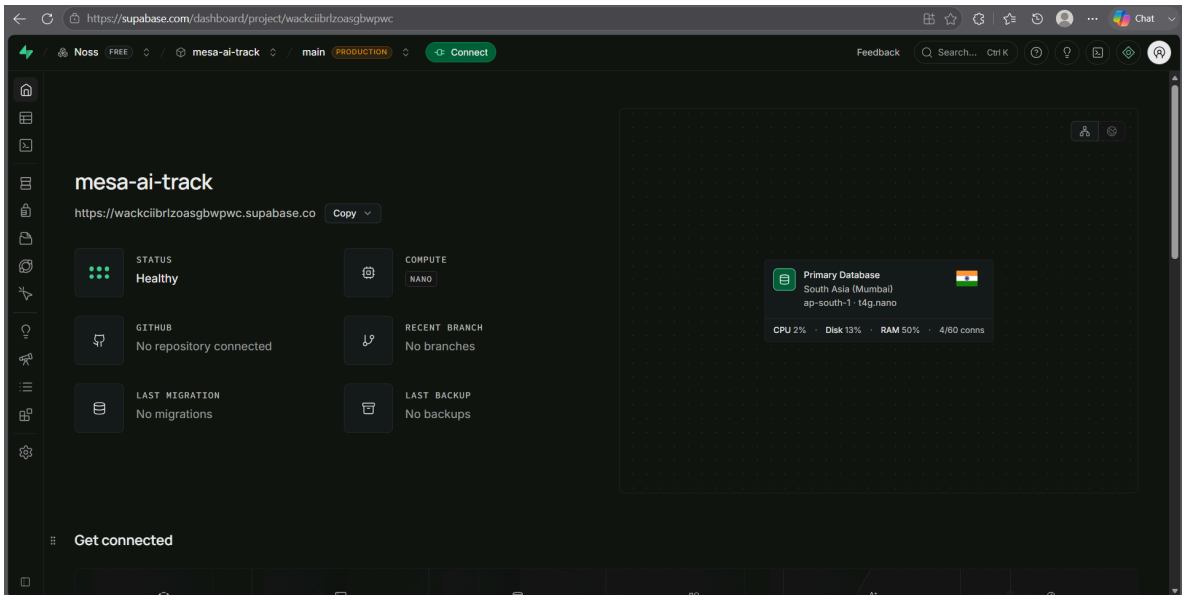


STEP 4 — Create the project

Click the green Create new project button at the bottom of the form.

Supabase will now set up your project. This takes approximately one to two minutes. A loading screen will appear with a progress indicator. Do not refresh the page - let it complete on its own.

Once the setup is complete, you will land on your project dashboard.



PART 3 — SAVE YOUR API KEYS

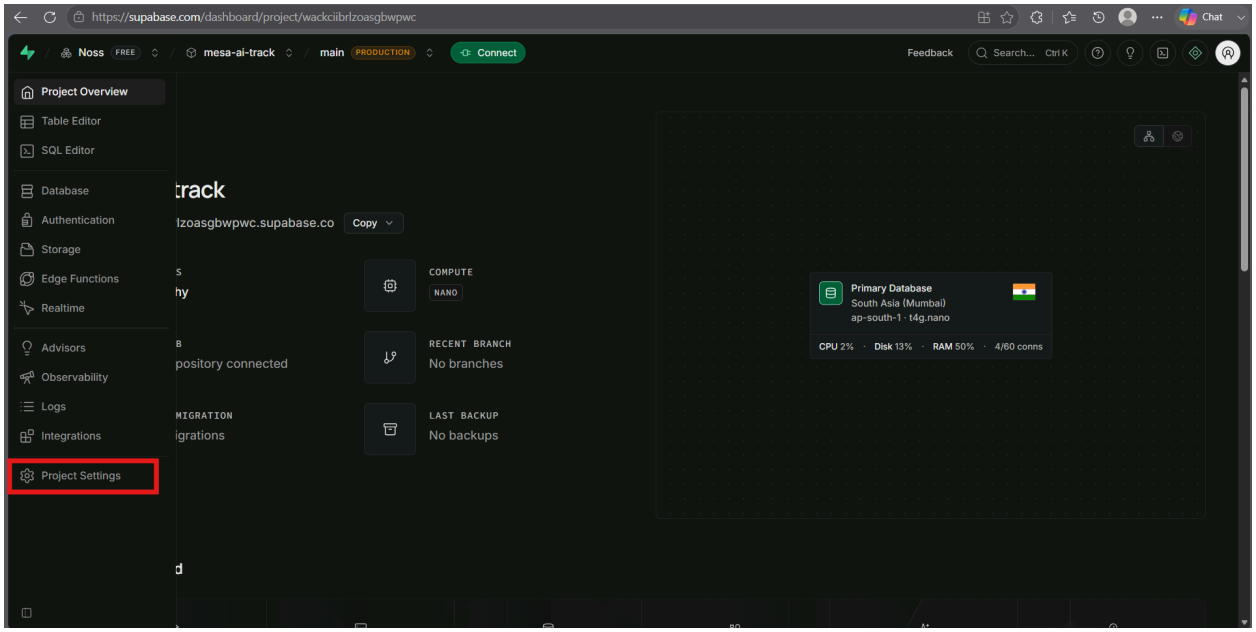
WHY DO YOU NEED API KEYS?

Your app needs two pieces of information to talk to your Supabase database: the Project URL (where the database lives) and the API Key (the password that lets your app in). Both go into your .env file.

STEP 5 — Open your project API settings

In the left sidebar of your project dashboard, click Settings (the gear icon, near the bottom of the sidebar).

On the Settings page, click “API Keys” in the left sub-menu.



The page title "API Settings" or "Project API Keys" should be visible.

Step 6 — Copy your Publishable key

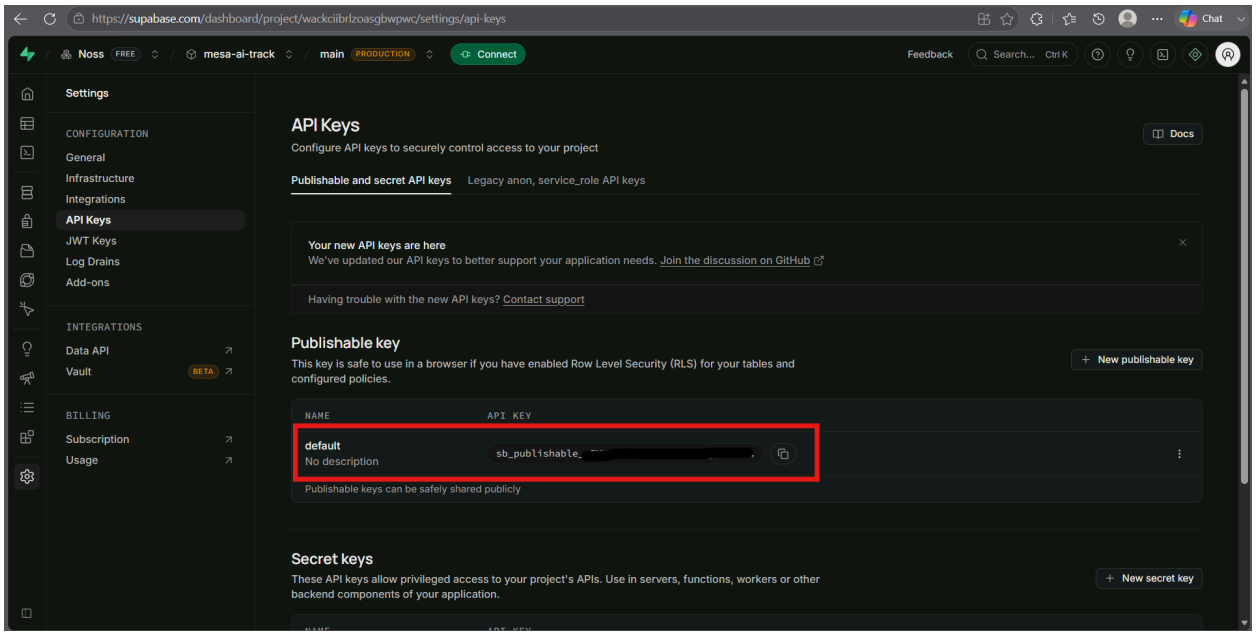
You will see two sections on this page: **Publishable key** and **Secret keys**.

Find the Publishable key section. It shows one key labelled "default" with a key string beginning with `sb_publishable_`. Click the copy icon next to it.

Paste it into your notes and label it clearly:

SUPABASE_PUBLISHABLE_KEY = [paste here]

The page notes that publishable keys are safe to use in a browser - this is the key your app's frontend will use.



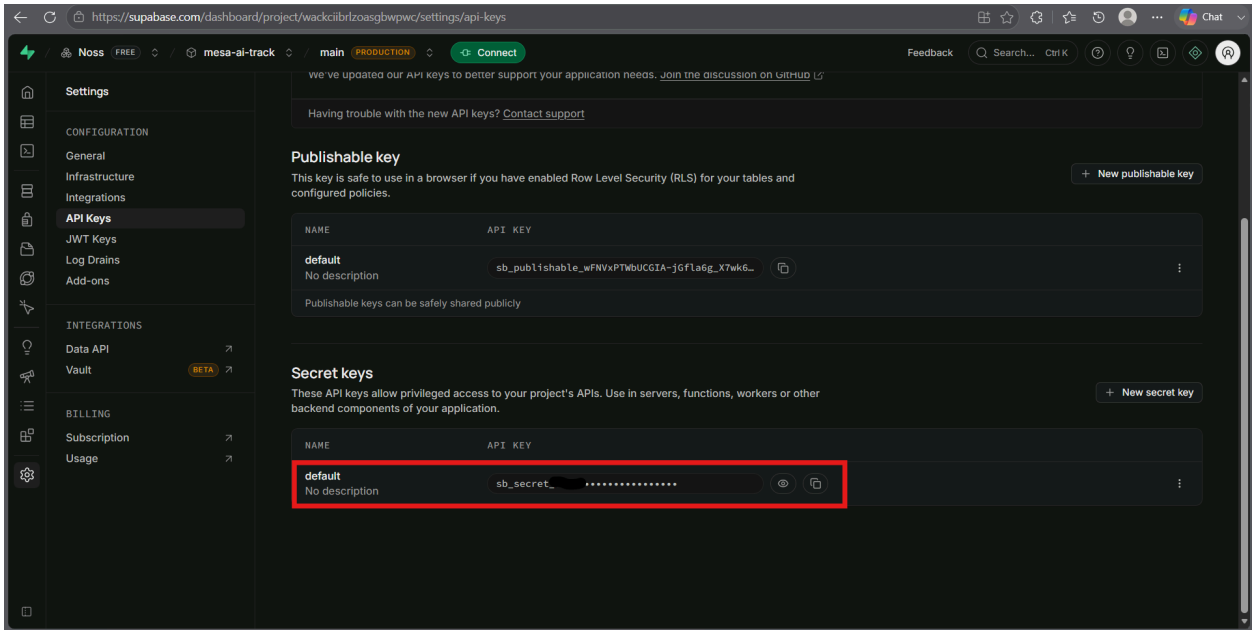
Step 7 — Copy your Secret key

Scroll down to the **Secret keys** section. You will see a key labelled "default" beginning with `sb_secret_`. This key is masked by default - click the eye icon to reveal it, then click the copy icon.

Paste it into your notes and label it:

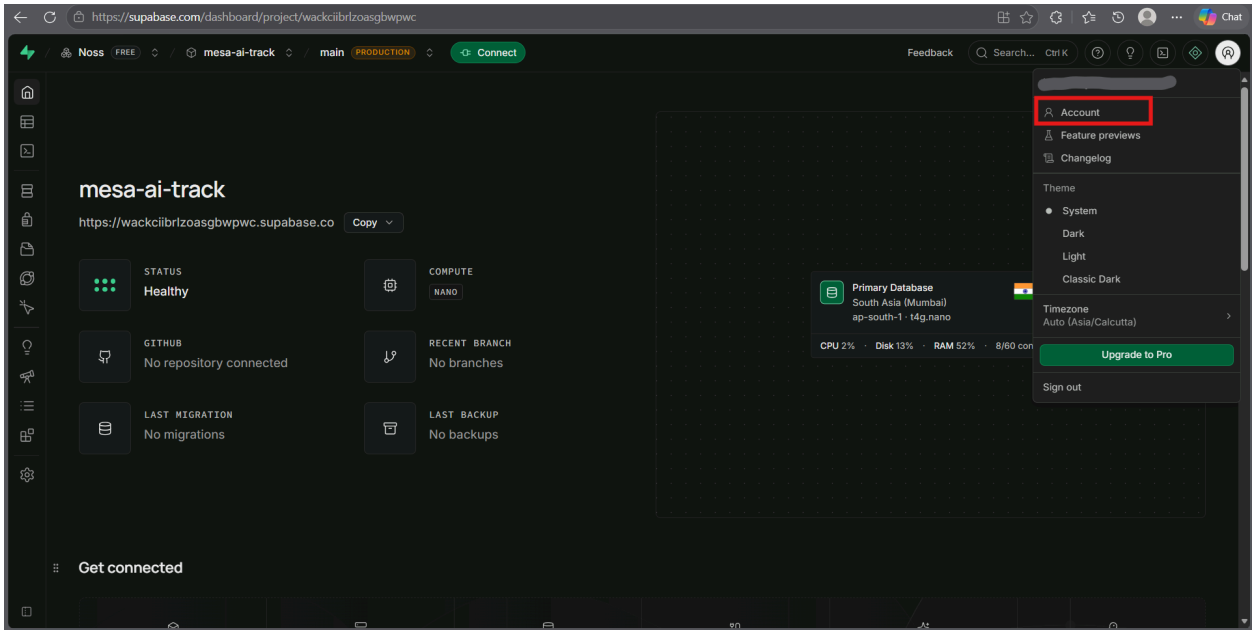
SUPABASE_SECRET_KEY = [paste here]

Keep this key strictly private. Unlike the publishable key, this one grants privileged access to your database and should never appear in frontend code, a public repository, or any shared document.



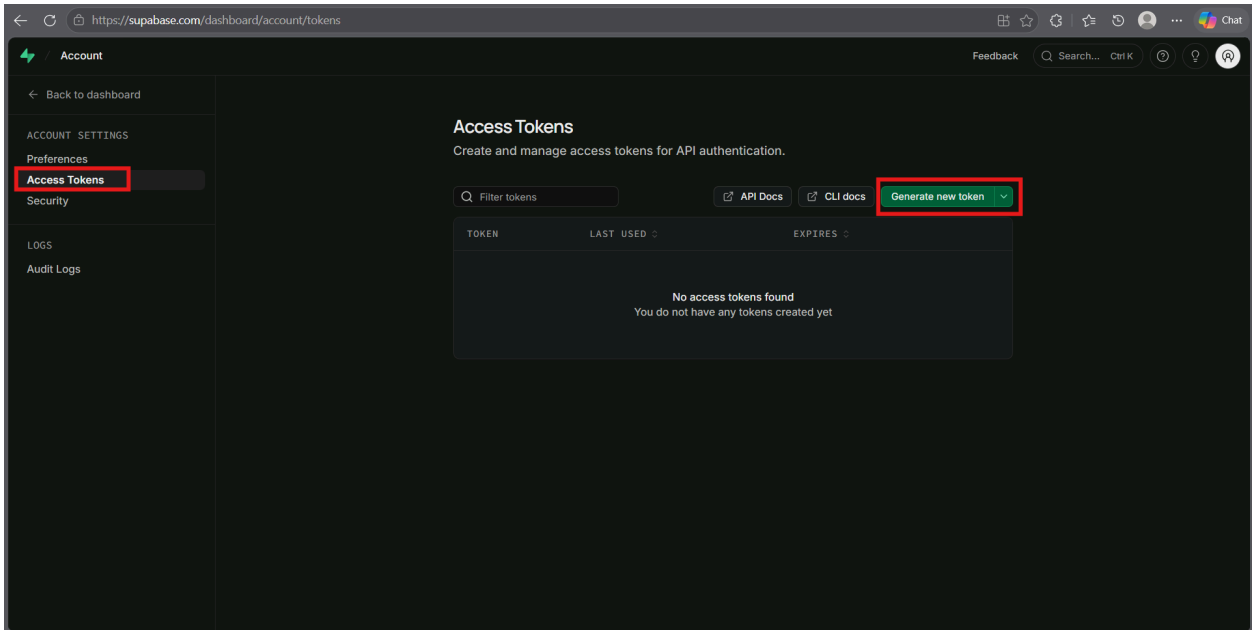
Step 8 — Open Account Settings

On the ‘Profile’ icon - top right corner - click on the **Account** button to access Account Settings.

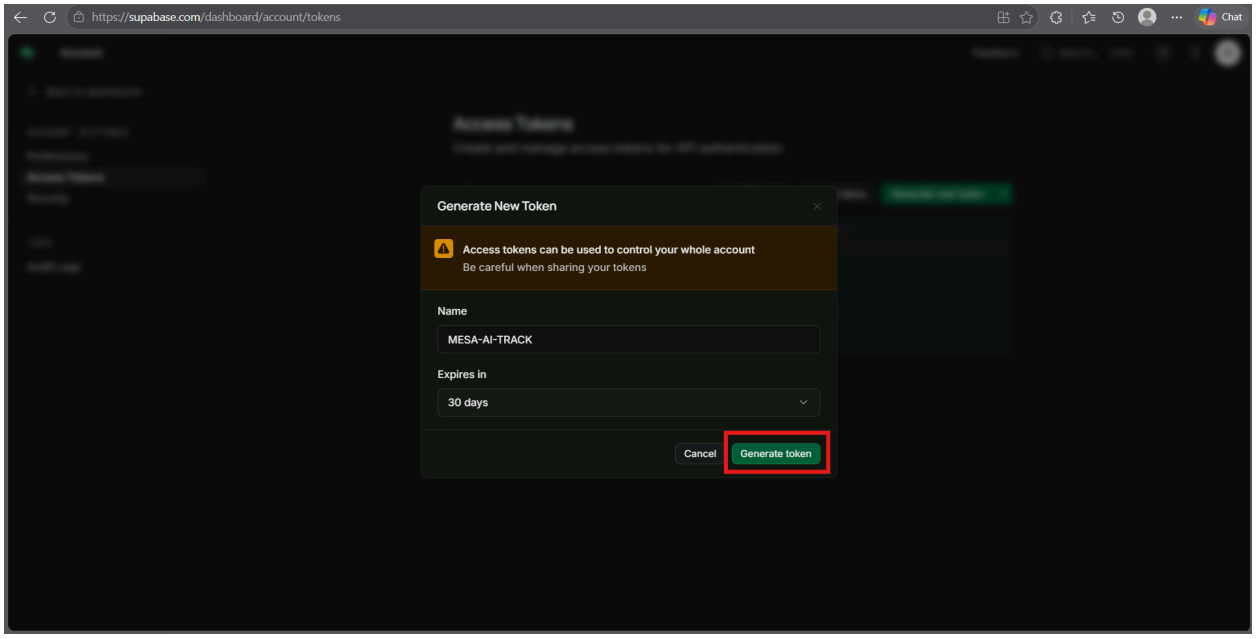


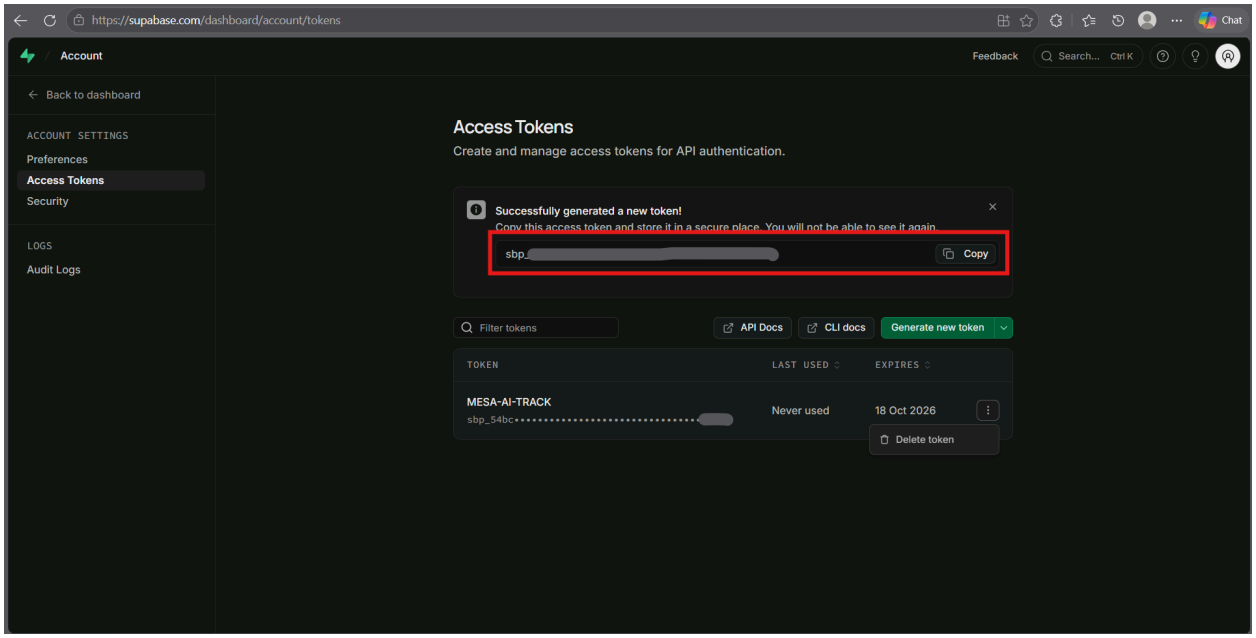
Step 9 — Generate Access Token

Click on the Access Tokens selection on the left pane. When the page opens, click on the **Generate new token**, which opens a pop-up window.



Enter the name - MESA-AI-TRACK and click on the **Generate token** button.





YOU ARE DONE

Before Lecture 1, confirm you have saved all three of the following in the same place as your GitHub token:

- ☐ Database password (from Step 2)
- ☐ SUPABASE_URL (from Step 6)
- ☐ SUPABASE_PUBLISHABLE_KEY (from Step 7)
- ☐ SUPABASE_SECRET_KEY (from Step 7)
- ☐ SUPABASE_ACCESS_TOKEN (from Step 9)

These three values, along with your GitHub Personal Access Token, are the credentials your apps will use this month. Keep them safe, accessible, and never share them publicly.